2026 State of Kubernetes Fleet Management Report

This is a preview.

April 2026

Red Hat

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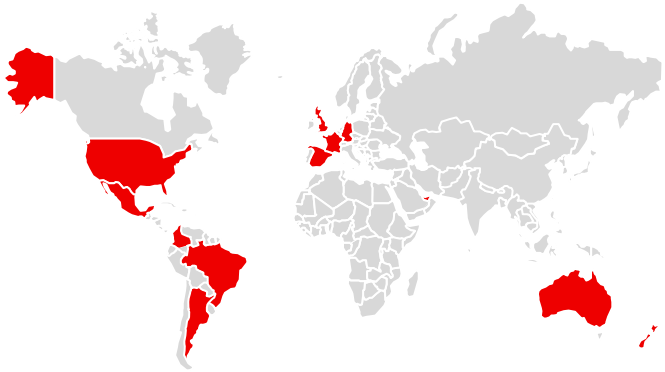
Research focus:

This research explores how organizations are managing Kubernetes fleets to regain visibility, governance, and operational control as environments scale over the next 1–2 years.

Geographic scope

785 completed surveys



365	180	190	50
US	EMEA	APAC	LATAM
	UK, Germany, France, Spain, United Arab Emirates	Australia , New Zealand, Hong Kong, Singapore	Brazil, Argentina, Colombia, Mexico

Methodology

Online survey
Methodology

Mar 2 – 23, 2026
Field dates

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Operational maturity defines Kubernetes success at scale

Insights from Kubernetes fleet leaders show:

Most organizations are still maturing

Even with Kubernetes widely deployed in production, many organizations remain in intermediate stages, with inconsistent processes and limited standardization.

Maturity drives clear differences in outcomes

Organizations with more advanced, policy-driven approaches achieve greater control, fewer disruptions, and higher confidence in managing Kubernetes environments.

Future complexity will widen the maturity gap

As environments scale and diversify, organizations with stronger operational foundations will be better positioned to manage increasing demands.

Organizations must improve consistency, control, and operational discipline to manage Kubernetes effectively at scale as environments grow more complex.

Kubernetes at scale

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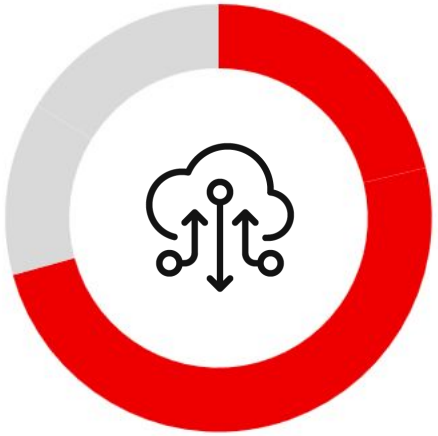
Kubernetes environments span clouds, regions, and constraints

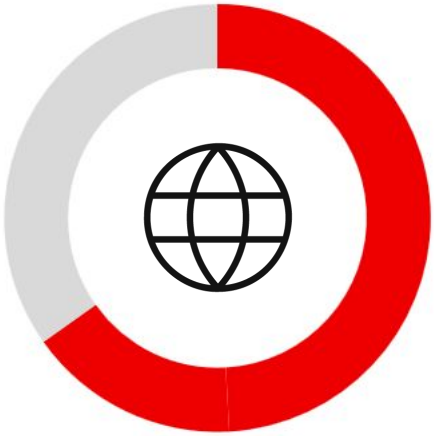
Multi-environment Kubernetes operations are the standard across organizations.

Public cloud footprint



70% use multiple providers

Geographic distribution



65% operate across regions

Connectivity constraints

65% operate air-gapped or intermittently connected clusters

Base Size = 785
Q1. How many different public cloud providers does your organization use for Kubernetes today?
Q3. How geographically distributed are your Kubernetes clusters?
Q2. Does your organization run any Kubernetes clusters in disconnected or air-gapped environments?

The challenge of control

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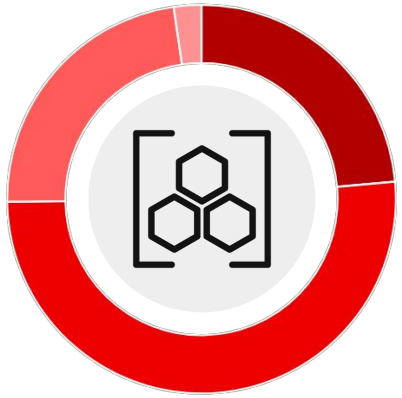
Enforcement appears consistent, but breaks in practice

Policies are frequently overridden in real-world environments.

Existence of fleet-wide standards



- 24% Fleet-wide standards are automatic
- 51% Fleet-wide standards are defined
- 23% Standards exist, but they vary
- 2% No defined standards or policies

Consistency does not eliminate exceptions

70%

report a high level of consistency in policy enforcement

- but -

75%

regularly override policies to address operational needs.

Base Size = 785

Q14. Does your organization have defined standards or policies that apply across its Kubernetes clusters?

Q16. How consistent is policy enforcement across the different environments where you run Kubernetes (for example, cloud, on-premises, edge)? (reporting mostly / completely consistent)

Q17. How often are standards or policies overridden to address operational needs? (reporting occasionally / often / very often)

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Execution under strain

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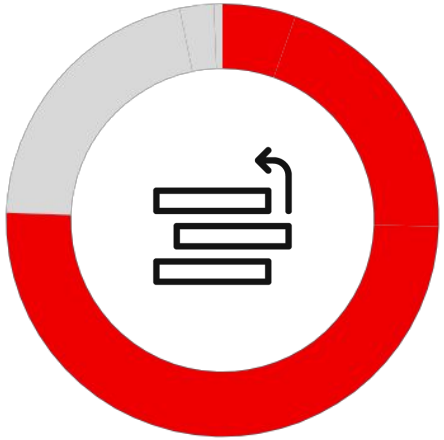
Execution outcomes are inconsistent and resource-intensive

Drift is common, effort is high, and outcomes are not fully predictable.

Configuration drift



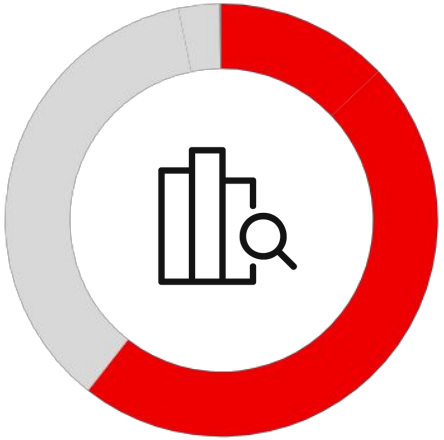
76% experience drift at least occasionally

Maturity signal: Decreases to 48% among the most mature (Policy-driven fleet operators)

Operational effort

91% report moderate to high effort

Outcome predictability



60% report predictable outcomes

Maturity signal: Increases to 92% among the most mature (Policy-driven fleet operators)

Base Size = 785
Q23. How often does your organization encounter configuration drift across Kubernetes clusters? (reporting occasionally / often / very often)
Q24. How would you describe the level of effort required to keep Kubernetes clusters aligned with desired configurations and standards? (reporting moderate / high / very high)
Q25. How predictable are the outcomes when changes are made across your Kubernetes environments? (reporting mostly / highly predictable)

Pressure is building

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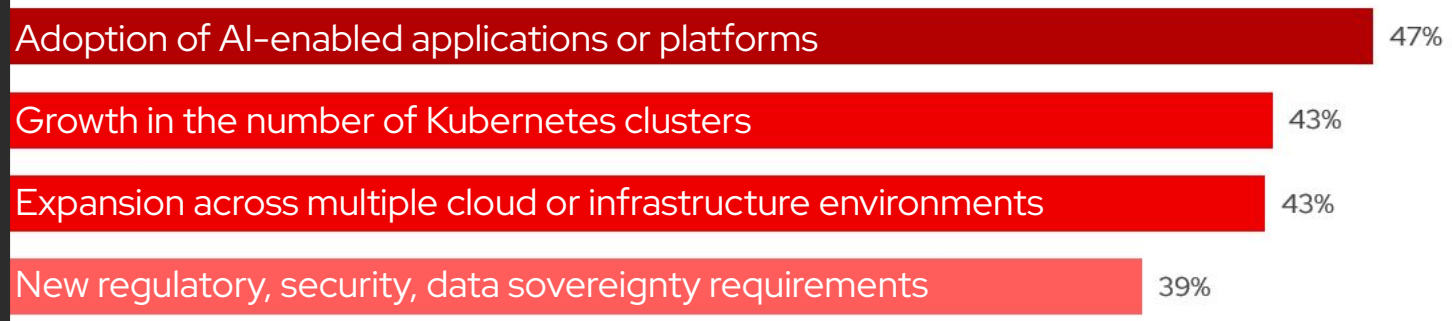
Complexity is increasing from multiple directions

AI adoption, growth, multicloud expansion, and regulation will further strain operational complexity.

Complexity is driven by convergence, not a single factor.

Multiple forces are compounding, making Kubernetes environments more difficult to manage consistently at scale.

Top drivers of future complexity



Other contributing factors

- Increased expectations from development teams
- Support for edge or remote Kubernetes deployments
- Increased geographic or regional distribution
- Geopolitical or regulatory Changes
- Mergers, acquisitions, or divestitures

Base Size = 785

Q41. Over the next 1–2 years, which of the following do you expect will most increase the complexity of managing Kubernetes in your organization? (select up to 3)

Wrap up

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What organizations must do to operate Kubernetes at scale:

Fleet management must evolve from tooling to operating model

Success will depend on how organizations structure ownership, standardize processes, and manage Kubernetes consistently across environments.

Point solutions will not resolve systemic complexity

Improving performance will require coordinated progress across governance, lifecycle management, visibility, and platform capabilities.

AI will accelerate operations, but not replace the need for discipline

AI-assisted capabilities will improve efficiency and decision-making, but organizations must still establish strong operational foundations to benefit from them.

Red Hat Advanced Cluster Management for Kubernetes

End-to-end management for clusters and applications from a unified console

Included in Red Hat OpenShift Platform Plus

Accelerate software development
with self-service provisioning

Increase application availability & deployment speed
with placement rules to quickly deploy in different locations to match capacity

Simplify IT operations
with self-service to allow teams to directly set up cluster environments

More easily meet compliance requirements
with centralized policy enforcement across environments

Reduce operational costs for multicloud environments
with a single management environment

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Get all the details and insights

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